central section, so creating a channel deep enough for shallow-draught coastal craft to slip through in calm weather, though it remained too risky for bulkier sea-going vessels. This meant that when the Portuguese navigators first came that way they had little option but to turn about and head south, which led them to the natural shelter that became the harbour of Colombo. So it came about that Lanka fell to the Portuguese, who then turned their attentions to the East Indies. It also meant that India's eastern seaboard, the Coromandel coast, was left almost unscathed for later European maritime powers to exploit.

Thanks to the havoc wrought by the Portuguese, Ludovico and his Persian friend were forbidden to sell the merchandise they had brought with them to Calicut. They had no option but to move on. 'And so we departed,' writes Ludovico, 'and made our road by a river, which is the most beautiful I ever saw, and arrived at a city which is called Cacalon [modern Kumarakom]' – a description that will resonate with anyone who has ever travelled by boat along the palm-fringed backwaters of Kerala. They returned to the coast at Colon – modern Quilon (Kollam) – only to find the local raja besieged by his enemies. So they kept on moving, rounding the southern cape by boat to reach the port of Chail, modern Tuticorin (Thuthukodi), which now houses a major container port but was then the centre of a thriving pearl fishing industry very much under the thumb of a wealthy Arab trader.

In order to continue their journey up the coast they hired a vessel known locally as a *ciampana*, which from Ludovico's description – 'they are flat-bottomed, and require little water and carry much goods' – must have been something akin to a Chinese sampan. It was seaworthy enough to get the travellers safely through the Bridge of Rama, despite 'great peril because there are many shoals and rocks there'. They then sailed on up the east coast until they came to 'a city which is called Cioromandel',